INNOVATION LABS 2027

2027 REVAMP · SUMMARY

Fewer teams, more support. Founders think first, AI challenges.

The 2026 program is fundamentally sound. The 2027 revamp closes the gaps the cohort named, tests one hypothesis about AI use, and adds IL Beyond to bridge Demo Day and fundability.

80 → 41
Teams accepted into the program, 2025 vs 2026. Intake halved.

17
Teams at Demo Day in both years. Half the intake, same number of finalists.

about 53 h
Mentoring per team in 2026, from roughly 2,200 donated hours by 221 mentors.

about 25
Of 41 teams, those judged worth full program resources in the 2026 read.

WHAT 2026 TOLD US

Strong community. Uneven structure.

- Community and networking are the dominant value driver; Bootcamp 1 and Pitch Prep rated highest.
- Hardware teams are underserved by a software-biased mentor pool.
- Mentor advice contradicts itself, with no way to reconcile it.
- The schedule was compressed, and deliverables were not consistently fed back on.
- Online semifinals and the hybrid format broke continuity.

THE HYPOTHESIS WE TEST

AI as a challenger, not an author

01	02	03	04
Think in analog	**Think together**	**Challenge with AI**	**Human synthesis**
Paper first, before any model	Defend reasoning to peers	Find blind spots, not drafts	The founder decides

A reasoned bet, not a proof: the research is recent and partly correlational. We test it on our own teams through deliverable quality between Bootcamp 1 and 2, plus a per-team AI-use log.

WHAT CHANGES FOR 2027

Curriculum

- Paper-first exercises inserted into existing blocks, not added time
- AI literacy track and a "How AI Tricks You" course
- Integrity rule: real interviews, sourced competitors

Mentoring

- 2 to 3 hands-on mentors per team, business and tech
- PODS of 3 to 5 teams for the whole program
- Vetted mentor core; mentors evaluate deliverables

Cohort and evaluation

- Cut after Bootcamp 2 plus a one-week buffer
- Separate B2C, B2B, software and hardware criteria
- New KPI: deliverable quality and feedback delivery

NEW TRACK · IL BEYOND

From finalist to fundable

JUL – SEP
S1 Build
6 teams · PMF and a technical moat

OCT – DEC
S2 Sell
3–4 teams · incorporation, contracts, round prep

JAN – FEB
S3 Raise
2 teams · term sheet to money in the bank

TARGETS AND RESOURCES

- At least 2 companies sign a term sheet for a EUR 300k–500k pre-seed round; at least 1 sees the money land.
- Up to EUR 38,800 per team, incl. IL's EUR 20,000 angel bridge; proposed budget EUR 190,480 with angels (6 › 4 › 2).
- EGV Investment Prize moves from Demo Day to the close of Stage 3, subject to EGV's agreement.

DECISIONS NEEDED BEFORE LAUNCH

Travel-burden offset
For non-Bucharest teams, given the Regional Hub downgrade.

Evaluation criteria for the cut
Including separate B2C, B2B, software and hardware rubrics.

Owners for open roles
Tech and product reviews for IL Beyond; the WhatsApp community.

SOURCE: INNOVATION LABS 2027 REVAMP MASTER NOTES

2027 FIGURES ARE ESTIMATES OR PROPOSALS